



TRANSFER SCHOOL SELECTION GUIDE

Build a Strategic Transfer List Based on Data,
Not Wishful Thinking

IvyAmbition

T14 Law School Admissions Consulting



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CHAPTER 01

The Transfer Targeting Framework

Transfer targeting is fundamentally different from 1L targeting. Your LSAT and undergraduate GPA are nearly irrelevant. What matters: your **1L class rank**, **your current school's reputation**, and **the target school's historical transfer patterns**.

The Three Tiers

Reach Schools

1-2 schools

Your rank is at the low end of their historical transfer admits. Worth applying but don't count on them.

Target Schools

3-4 schools

Your rank falls solidly within their typical transfer admit range. These are where you're most likely to land.

Likely Schools

1-2 schools

Your rank exceeds their typical transfer admits. Near-certain admission and potential scholarship leverage.

CHAPTER 02

Transfer-Friendly vs Transfer-Hostile

✓ TRANSFER-FRIENDLY (High Volume)

Georgetown: Enrolls 80-120 transfers/year. Largest transfer class in the T-14.

Columbia: 50-70 transfers. Strong from T-30 and above schools.

NYU: 40-60 transfers. Particularly receptive to public interest-oriented transfers.

Harvard: 25-40 transfers. Competitive but enrolls more transfers than most students realize.

Northwestern: 25-40 transfers. Values work experience even for transfers.

Penn: 20-35 transfers. Consistent and relatively predictable.

X TRANSFER-SELECTIVE (Low Volume)

Stanford: Fewer than 15 typically. Hardest T-14 to transfer into.

Yale: Rarely takes transfers. Effectively closed for most applicants.

Chicago: Small transfer class, unpredictable outcomes.

→ **STRATEGY:** Build your list around the transfer-friendly schools. Add 1-2 selective schools as reaches if your numbers support it. Don't build an entire list of long shots.

CHAPTER 03

Using Data to Build Your List

1 LSD.law Transfer Data

Law School Data tracks transfer outcomes. Filter by your current school, class rank range, and target. Look for patterns: does this school consistently take from your school? What rank range gets in?

2 ABA 509 Reports

Every school publishes annual data including number of transfers in and out. Track trends across 3-5 years. A school that took 50 transfers last year but only 30 two years before may be expanding — or last year was an outlier.

3 Feeder School Patterns

Some T-14 schools consistently draw from specific feeder schools. If your school has a track record of students transferring to a particular T-14, that's a strong signal. Talk to your dean of students — they often have this data informally.

4

Transfer Forums and Communities

Reddit's r/lawschooladmissions and TLS (Top Law Schools) have transfer-specific threads with self-reported data. Not perfectly reliable but useful for calibrating expectations.

CHAPTER 04

The Financial Calculus

Transferring typically means paying full tuition for 2L and 3L. If you had a scholarship at your current school, you're giving it up. The question isn't whether transferring costs more — it almost always does. The question is whether the career outcome differential justifies the cost.

1

BigLaw-Bound Students

If transferring takes you from a school with 20% BigLaw placement to a T-14 with 70%+ placement, the expected value calculation strongly favors transferring. The \$80-150K additional cost is recovered in 2-3 years of BigLaw salary.

2

Public Interest Students

More complex. If you have a full scholarship at your current school, transferring to pay full tuition at a T-14 for PI may not make financial sense. Exception: if the T-14 has a strong LRAP that would cover payments, the math changes dramatically.

3

The Scholarship Question

Some transfers do receive money — especially if admitted to multiple T-14 schools. Use competing offers as leverage. Even \$20-40K/year reduces the cost gap significantly.

Application Volume Strategy

Apply to **5-8 schools minimum**. Transfer outcomes are more volatile than 1L outcomes. A student might get into Columbia but be rejected from Georgetown, or vice versa. More applications = more chances for a favorable outcome.

★ **THE MATH:** Each application costs \$50-\$85. Applying to 8 schools costs ~\$500-\$700 total. The career difference between a T-14 and your current school could be worth **\$500,000+ in lifetime earnings**. Application fees are rounding errors in this calculus.

WANT A CUSTOM TRANSFER TARGET LIST?

IvyAmbition builds personalized transfer school lists based on your exact rank, school, and goals.

Book a free 15-minute consultation at ivyambition.com